3

A haze consumed him, dulling his ability to pay attention to anything save for an acute pain, sharp and digging somewhere that he couldn't quite place. It swelled at times, though, pushing out anything else, eliminating even a sense of his whole physical scale, swallowing all of him into it. In those crests, he did not *have* pain, he *was* pain, and he yearned then to surrender to unconsciousness.

Just as another attack seemed to finally wane, and he would experience even a modicum of relief, a noise cut through the fog of his brain. Startled, he came to, focused on nothing else except stopping the excruciating torture of the repetitive, piercing sound, and his hands scrambled blindly to locate whatever device needed destroying. Instead of finding it, though, something grabbed him.

His eyes shot open, hand automatically reaching underneath his pillow to find the grip of his pistol. Fingers quickly found his wrist, though, pinning his arm down.

"Don't!" she commanded. "It's just me."

Han twisted around to see a smattering of thick, dark curls. As his vision focused, he made out the full lips and the copper eyes, both frowning at him. Salla.

Seeing the recognition in his face, she pulled her hand off his, then held out something in front of his nose. "Your comm has been chirping," she said flatly. Still dazed, he gawked down at it, and she shook it at him again. "Take it!"

He obeyed, then stared at it another moment, beginning to remember, before he instinctively answered. "Solo," he yelped, almost a question, as he struggled to hold his head up.

"Nice of you to finally answer."

It took a few seconds, but he recognized the voice, then groaned as he fell back onto the bed. After writhing there for a breath, he lifted the comm back up to his mouth. "Hi, Deino."

"I told you I would call when we were ready." Always with her clipped tone.

He paused for a moment, eager to draw out the conversation, if only to delay the inevitable. "Yeah," he finally managed. "Alright. I'm coming." He let go of a long exhale. "Gimme…gimme an hour."

As soon as he heard the line close, he collapsed back on the bed, the comm tumbling from his grip and slipping somewhere insignificant. Aching, he raised hands to his temples, pressing palms into his forehead. In doing so, he found ever so slight a reduction in the pressure across his brow, and he froze, as much absorbed in the sudden and inexplicable euphoria as he was afraid that moving would bring the anguish back even worse.

He had an hour, he reasoned faintly. That meant he didn't need to get up right away. If he could fall back asleep, maybe even for just twenty minutes, maybe he'd wake up and this throbbing in his head would have ebbed. He sank back into the bed, the light fading from his eyelids.

He couldn't tell whether he'd only blinked or shut his eyes or passed out when he heard her again.

"No, *get up*," she insisted, and then he was being jostled around. He jerked his head up to see Salla gripping the edge of her bedsheets, attempting to pull them out from underneath him. "C'mon," she scowled, "I have to leave, too, and I want this place straightened up before I go."

He waved her away, hand reaching for his forehead again, and she walked off with an interjection of disgust.

"I'll get up," he called after her. He located the comm again and checked the time through a squint, then let go of a moan of relief: he'd slept, but not long. He had just enough time to get to the Palace, but only if he got up now. Once again, he brought his hands to his eyes and rubbed aggressively. The massaging helped soothe some of the stabbing, so he kept at it, though when he dropped his hands, the ceiling swirled with color.

Letting go of another large exhale, he managed to prop himself up, then took a glance at the space around him. Salla's apartment was small, like his, but clean, if a little utilitarian. In a

chair in the corner, she had sat a full bag with her boots propped up neatly beneath it. A bag meant a long trip, usually one with multiple stops.

Though little better, but resolving he'd best get a move on, he spun with effort and planted feet on the floor…almost. His toes wiggled in something lumpy but pliable. He peered down to find his clothes had been gathered in a pile. He nudged them around, searching for his shirt, then found the gray tunic and stuffed his arms inside before tossing it over his head. Socks. Underwear. Pants next, though when he stood to finish pulling them on, his head swam.

"Fuck," he grunted at the fullness of his indulgence the night before. All of him ached, and he went down limp again on the bed, powerless against it.

"I told you not to drink that whole bottle," he heard from the 'fresher.

She had, and he had taken it as a challenge. The Nar Shadesse liked to brag about their home grown and distilled liquor, a potent spirit they often used to compete with one another to see how many shots they could take and stay upright. Salla was no different, and she'd warned him not to try to outdo her. He'd grinned at her as he took another shot of *yannis*, determined to impress. As his hand found his brow to attempt to shield against the brightness of the room, he admitted his folly.

An injection of caffeine–that would wipe out the throbbing at his temple. With clear purpose now, he roused himself again and meandered into the kitchenette, pausing at the threshold in surprise. The whole cook area was pristine: every dish had been washed, every item put away, the counter wiped down. Absolutely no evidence remained of the seared bantha filet and white sauce he'd prepared for them the night before. He'd heard none of her cleaning, only then accepting just how hard he'd slept.

He already felt the beginnings of relief as he found a container of ready-stimm. He started a kettle, then threw hands on his hips, his eyes sweeping again over the immaculate space. Despite his

awareness of the effort it must have taken to strip the kitchen of his mess, his insides rumbled with impatience. Tea would not be enough, he admitted; he needed something on his gut to help sop up whatever alcohol still swirled in his system. He raided the cooler, finding last night's filet perfectly wrapped up and the sauce in a perfectly sized dish. Tucked away in a cabinet, he found the bottle of Corellian wine, only a third left, that he'd started before switching to the *yannis*. He didn't bother to reheat anything, nor even sit as he ate. Mindlessly, he gnashed, only as he finished even able to taste any of the food, and in doing so, congratulated himself on another flawless execution of the meal.

"You're going to stink this place up with that stuff," Salla snided as she entered the kitchen, eyeing the mug he'd placed behind him on the counter. "And I hope you'll leave this space like you found it."

He leaned into the counter a little more, then gestured at her with the last bite of the steak. She eyed him, unimpressed, then reached into the cooler and pulled out a protein smoothie. She took a pull on it, then a second. "How long 'til you report?"

Han swallowed as he checked the chrono on the wall. "'Bout half an hour," he reasoned, and at the realization, began to assemble his stimm. A few spoonfuls of instant powder and a heavy pour of hot water later, and he had sludge in his cup. This wouldn't be enjoyable, but it'd be quick, and it'd help.

They stood silently beside each other, each drinking their breakfast but absorbed in their own musings. Han's, though still muddy, rechurned the last few days. They'd been tumultuous, to put it lightly. Pulling the *Starmite* together had been the least of his hiccups, though she'd certainly required some elbowing to get the replacement valves installed. His shoulder still ached from having to hitch himself in all awkward in the engine room.

But Chewbacca–that had been his biggest headache. The Wook had managed to forgive the disappearing act Han had pulled. Well, mostly. He'd thrown a fit about the trip, though. No matter

what the Hutts said, it didn't pass a smell test, Chewie insisted. Han, not exactly enthusiastic–far from it–but too cognizant of what he stood to gain, did his utmost to reassure. And besides, he'd added, how could the girl be a slave and do so much, be given so much leeway? They both knew slavery upfront, he'd reminded the Wookiee, and this wasn't it. At that, there had been grumbling in response, but the arguing at least had ceased.

Han sipped his stimm tea again. In his periphery, he could see Salla doing the same. They probably could have stood around in silence all morning if neither of them had to go anywhere. That was one of the things he liked about her: she respected his privacy. She kept her distance, and she didn't expect he spill his guts or divulge his whereabouts. They met at her apartment, they talked shit and traded stories and recommendations for parts, they tousled in her bed, and that was it.

But today…he couldn't get out of his own head. Much as he'd argued back with Chewie, he had his own suspicions. He had a sense he still didn't understand what he'd gotten himself into. Salla might. She might be able to tip him off before he got too deep. Worth it, he decided, to share.

He cleared his throat first. "Uh, I got tasked with something by the Hutts. Something…different."

Salla looked at him expectantly, waiting for him to continue.

He sighed first, committed to appearing nonchalant. "Jiliac says there's someone at the palace trying to start some kind of entertainment venue." He felt conscious, somewhere, to not mention it was a woman. "They need to head to Esseles to pick up more talent, I guess."

Salla's brow arched in dry skepticism. "Not enough here?"

"Guess not," he offered as he shrugged. "Chewie says it's suspicious. He thinks they're being secretive, like…like this might be something more than just transport."

"Escort?"

"Trafficking," he answered, again trying to act as though the

word didn't hang in his throat. He gestured at her. "I dunno, you're from here–what do you think?"

She finished her smoothie, turning to the sink to rinse out the container. "I don't pay attention to what they do. We leave them alone, they leave us alone."

"That's not very helpful," he grumbled.

"I don't know what to tell you," Salla rocketed back. "They have contracts all over this moon. Who the hell knows what new imported favorite they're promoting while they leave us to bicker for scraps."

He frowned at her word choice. "Hey, you make it like we're all bad."

"Not you," she snapped, "not the pilots. *Them*. The little closed circle they keep. The foreign influence they allow. And the *igibala* who mess with them." Scowling, she swiftly left the kitchen.

Shouldn't have asked, Han rued, hovering for a moment longer in resignation before he rinsed his cup, then left it in the sink. He needed to get a move on–his window was dwindling.

He came to the entryway and slipped a foot in his boot. It gave fairly easily, a testament to its age and wear, and he pulled up on it and carefully tucked his pants. As he finished putting on the second, Salla returned, voicelessly holding his holster out to him. He took it, grinning, eager to see those strong umber cheekbones lift with a faint smile in return.

As soon as he finished securing the belt, she handed him his gun, her eyebrow arched. "Why do you use a damaged blaster?"

"It's not damaged," he countered, holding it out for inspection. "It's *modified*."

Though he'd smirked at her as he said it, she didn't budge. "It's missing a scope."

"On purpose," he said, playfully incredulous. "No scope means nothin' to get caught on." He put the blaster in its holster, then smoothly pulled it out. "See?"

She rolled eyes at him, which he snickered at, then crossed her

arms, staring. She was waiting for him to leave.

He'd not dawdle. He double checked his pockets: he had his gun, IDs, comm, and some slips of a few denominations of coins. Everything else he needed waited for him on the ship.

He let go of a singular pant. "Alright," he announced, "I'm out." He inclined his head at her to say goodbye, and then slipped from the apartment.

With little time to spare, he damn near speedwalked across the Corellian Sector. When he made it to the main gate of the Hutt Palace, a guard alerted Han that he should cross around to a smaller entrance at the west. He grimaced at the redirection–Deino had said no such thing–but he uneasily followed instructions. Having never been anywhere but the main gate, he picked his way through the surrounding garden until he came to a gated courtyard with two Twi'lek guards. After explaining himself, they let him pass, and he surveyed the exterior, picking out the large door ahead.

Figuring that Deino of course had been alerted to his arrival, he strolled over to a small, shaded terrace with a fountain in the middle. He checked his chrono: less than an hour, like he'd promised. Satisfied with himself, he reached for his comm and dictated a message for Chewie, alerting the Wookiee to head over to the Spacebarn.

His head ached still, and he winced against the throbbing. If he was being honest with himself, he conceded as he rubbed his scalp again, his drinking binge last night wasn't wholly rooted in bravado. Rather than dissipating, his wariness upon agreeing to travel to Esseles had only worsened into angst. It had festered in the back of his head as he'd tried to go about his routine, and knowing he'd need to get up the next morning and actually *go* had made the bottom of a bottle of *yannis* sound appetizing.

Now, to stand here and wait as the alcohol eased off, the apprehension returned. He checked the door again. Nothing. Unnerved, he started to pace, his eyes following the herringbone pattern in the pavers. In them, he could see the route he needed to

take. The Ootmian would take him counterspin, and then at Randon they could jump to its eponymous run. Neither of those especially bothered him–they'd been up and down both multiple times. It was the other end of the Randon Run that gave him pause. It terminated at Lantilles, where it junctioned with the Perliminian. Even if he managed to sidestep an Imperial patrol, whose presence was unlikely but not impossible, and they could enter the hyperspace lane unscathed, they'd still be heading Coreward. They'd exit at Esseles into well-established Imperial territory–a checkpoint; customs; the whole space crawling with ships of all sizes, all bearing that six-spoked roundel.

Regardless of what he'd said to the Hutts, he predicted that he could sidestep real trouble with them if the only thing they gave him a hard time about was his history. They'd rag on him, maybe rough him up, but it wouldn't be the first time, and as long as he could leave with his ship and his cargo, he'd take it. But Chewie…it was all different for Chewie. They'd argued about that, too–Han stuck between wanting him to stay and needing him to go. Strangely, the Wook insisted on going. They both understood, once they arrived, that he'd need to stay on the ship. It was getting there, and each step in between, where there was a chance for something to go wrong. The Imps were good at that–probing and asking for more and catching you in inconsistencies. They'd bury you under bureaucracy and protocol, and when that didn't work, they'd barge in and assault you, then claim it necessary or deserved. Han could put up a good front, but if the Imps didn't buy it, if they pushed past him, there'd be nothing he could do to stop them. His mouth twisted in irritation: this trip had only just begun, and his patience already ran thin.

Still no one at the door. He let go of a dramatic exhale, trying to shake it off, trying to coach himself into calm. *The money*, he reiterated, refocusing himself and his energy. In his head, he'd already started spending his payday. It was a habit he knew he should kick, but still. What four bands could do for him! A fresh start, for real this time–not his half-cocked attempt a year ago. No more

rubbing change together in order to buy third round used parts, no more having Chewie salvage through scrap or beg Shug. Hell, maybe he even sold the damn ship, finally got himself into something more suited to spacing. Whichever route he took, there was no doing it without some kind of extra funding.

Either in his pacing or palliative thoughts, he finally felt himself ease. *This doesn't need to be difficult*, he asserted. He ran through his ledger of resolved concerns: the transponder code had installed smoothly. His 'Suub, which carried some foreign name he'd never cared to decode or accurately memorize, now would show up on scanners as *Mantellian Sunrise*, a simple, personal cruiser registered to New Vertica. The aliases, he'd run them past a few people to find them clean, as the Hutts had promised. This could be the same as every other job. He just needed to play it cool, there and back, and they'd be fine.

The side door abruptly opened, and Han spun to see Deino step out and head towards him, followed by two figures who hung back, a human man and woman. He couldn't get that great of a look at them past Deino's sizable headdress, and instead tried to focus on straightening his posture as the majordomo approached.

"Here is your navigator," she announced brusquely, holding the device out to him. "The coordinates for your landing platform, the theater, and the hotel are already recorded."

His hand already outstretched, he hesitated only half a beat before receiving the device, his brow raised. "Hotel?"

"Our local contacts are also aware of your arrival. Their info is entered, should you need them."

Han eyed her as he pulled up the data. "You all concerned about trouble?"

Her head cocked. "Unpreparedness *invites* trouble."

He suppressed his grunt at her chide and resumed tooling the navigator. As he tinkered, though, he could feel Deino's eyes boring into him.

"You look like shit," she finally spat out, eyes narrowed in

scrutiny.

Still busied, Han answered her distractedly. “I got into a fight with a bottle of *yannis* and lost.”

“*Yannis*?” she exclaimed. “Are you fit to fly?!”

“I’m fine,” he returned, more concerned with the readout. The map of the city manifested on the display, and he made quick sense of its contents. In the middle of the arts district–from what he recalled, a ritzy quarter of the city–lay two markers. He inhaled to curb his surprise: the Hutts were indeed not skimping.

“Listen, Solo,” Deino continued, leaning in, “this job is big. It’s important that you do it right. She matters a lot to Jiliac.”

Doubting, Han leaned past Deino and studied the two figures. He’d seen the woman’s face already, though slightly scrambled in the holo readout of her alias ID. In person, likewise, she appeared rather unassuming. Cute and fit, sure, with long legs and broad shoulders, but nothing all that special in what appeared like black athletic wear. Her hair, a dark reddish brown, was simply tied away from her face and cascaded straight down her back. It was clear from her body language that she was listening to–but perhaps not absorbing–the lecture the older man was giving her. Despite the ruffle of the leaves in the trees, he could still make out the man’s gruff insistence, and the square of his shoulders and the straight line across his brow meant seriousness.

“Who’s the guy?” he asked, though he sensed he recognized him from somewhere. He was a broad, stocky man, with a neck thicker than a bantha’s. Bald headed, he donned some kind of austere uniform.

“Larsen, Head of Security for the Palace, though increasingly her personal bodyguard.”

“Are they *both* coming?!” he spat out, ready to sputter about the limited space on the ‘Suub.

“No–”

“No?” he interrupted.

Deino paused, vexation flashing in her eyes. “No,” she

repeated sternly. "He needs to stay here. You're in charge of her."

Han froze at first, then shifted his weight forward. "*In charge* of her? What the hell does that mean?"

"It means get her back here," Deino answered icily.

He bit at the inside of his cheek, remembering Chewie's wariness. Yeah, he could feel it now, that prickling at the back of his neck. This wasn't adding up. All this money, all the fussing, the need for *him* specifically to take her there, and now being 'in charge of her'? The anxiety about her returning. No, he could reluctantly agree: this didn't pass a smell test.

"Hey," he called to Deino in a hushed tone, leaning forward to close the distance. "Throw me a bone. What's the deal here? Who's the girl?"

Deino pursed her lips. "She's Jiliac's favorite, and you're tak–"

"Yeah, but what does that *mean*?"

She withdrew, looking long at him. "It's complicated."

He rubbed his lips together first in an ineffective effort to soothe. "Complicated *how*?"

Deino clearly chose her response carefully. "Complicated as in, you won't like the consequences if she comes back in another condition than I'm handing her to you."

His lips folded over. The Huttese word he needed to use sat heavy on his tongue, and a part of him questioned whether to even say it. It meant 'servant' in most contexts. In the Hutt Palace, it meant something much more narrow. His words came out tight and low, like a growl. "She's *woikeis*, isn't she?"

At his question, Deino recoiled, stiff. In her silence, he acknowledged what he always knew was true.

He scowled. "I asked Jabba," he hissed. "He said she was 'special'."

"She *is* special, you bore. And so are you–*you* have been selected." Deino uncoiled slightly, her head inclining as though to

reassure. “Just bring her back,” she appeased, adding just as she started to turn away, “and keep her safe.”

“Safe from *who?!*” he barked at her back, but Deino continued on.

He swiveled on his heel, his hand–the one holding the navigator–coming up to his chin as his head swirled. Or maybe the whole world was spinning? He sucked in a long breath, trying to find where to begin to unravel the torrent. His mind reached out, grasping with no purchase, until he finally pulled a thread and *hard*. Holding the idea in his mind’s eye, he inspected it, finding both relief and disappointment to process it: he needed to say no. He’d end up in Desilijic crosshairs if something went haywire on the trip, and something sure in his gut–hard and sickening–told him something *would*. Either Chewie or the Imps or this girl. *Woikeis*, he corrected bitterly. Fuck, what a problem. He’d already gotten himself in trouble once messing with this shit–that’s why he was *here*.

Not again. His only chance to come out of this scot free would be to not embark in the first place. He could lie, say something came up–engine trouble would always be believable–or even just hand the navigator back and tell her–tell Jiliac–no. There would be consequences for that, sure. He'd already raked himself across the coals enough trying to grovel for approval, even with Rho’s endorsement. Refusing this job might mean having to start from scratch…or even more behind. Still, he could survive the consequences for refusal. The same might not be true for failure.

Behind him, he heard Deino call his name. He reiterated to himself again–something was wrong with the ship, he’d make it up on the fly if pressed. He needed to just get the first part out of his mouth and the rest of it he could pull together. His throat tightened, the gravity of the moment pressing on him. He feebly swallowed against it; he couldn’t lose his train of thought. He’d take a breath, he coached himself, then spin and interrupt her, hand the navigator and the responsibility and the risk right back.

He turned back just as Deino closed with him. “Deino, I–”

"This is Korë Cali," Deino announced, her hand at the small of the girl's back. "Korë, this is–"

"Solo." The girl met warm, confident eyes with Han, taking the few steps between them in long strides, hand outstretched. "*Captain* Solo. I recognize you," she added, smirking.

He found himself unable to move at first. He stared at her smiling face for what he knew was too long. Only slowly, he remembered himself and his hand reached out to meet hers in greeting. Jiliac had asked him if he'd ever seen her; he felt sure now he hadn't. She had a pleasant smile, infectious even, and he wouldn't have forgotten that.

"You have everything you need?" Deino questioned.

The girl's hands automatically patted the bags she carried at either side. "I believe so. I double checked twice this morning."

Deino nodded, a warmth to her that Han had never seen before, but it cooled as she turned to the captain. "Solo here is a good pilot. He'll get you there safely."

At mention of him, the girl smiled again at Han. He was slow to return it, and did so only half-heartedly. "I don't have any doubts," she chirped. "You're Corellian, right?"

He chortled, a smidge surprised. "How can you tell?"

Again with that charming smile, and something else: there was depth to her dark eyes, and in them danced a glittering playfulness. "Aren't all the best pilots?"

That one landed. He couldn't help it—he flushed, part flustered, part confused. This was charisma, he registered, he'd almost even say flirtation. She was coherent. Cheerful. Clear-eyed. Not the sedated, ornamental drone he'd seen draped over the side of more than one Hutt. And confident, too–she held her head up and *looked* at him in a way that suggested nothing other than autonomy.

He remembered then that it was his turn to speak, and he scrambled for something clever. "Don't say that too loud," he managed, forcing a smarmy chuckle. "The Nar Shaddesse fancy themselves pretty strong candidates."

"I'm sure they do," she replied lightly, and then—just enough to unsettle him—she added, "but reputation and reality aren't always the same thing, are they?" She allowed only an additional beat before she gestured to the gate behind them. "Shall we go?"

"Yes, Captain Solo," Deino reiterated, a hard, challenging compulsion buried under the smoky amethyst of her iris, "you should get a move on."

Han's attention flickered between the two women, both waiting on him expectantly. He reached inward, trying to grasp back at his conviction, like a rope he could pull on to get himself out. His mind grasped at nothing. Whatever excuse, reason, lie he'd imagined, whatever moment he could have made a clean break—it was gone. The question of whether he would go had evaporated somewhere in the girl's smile–not a line in the sand to cross but a haze to walk through, and he was already on the other side of it.

"Uh, yeah," he heard himself answer. "Yeah, we can go."

Excited, the girl spun to Deino. They met in a hug, the older woman gripping the young girl tight, and rubbing her arm one last time.

"Come back in one piece," Deino said, quiet, almost mournfully. Then, as he and the girl turned to leave, the majordomo flashed those violet eyes at him one last time.

He nodded tightly: don't do anything stupid. He could do that.

They formally exited the Hutt Palace, then wove through the adjacent courtyards, heading back toward the Corellian Sector. She walked beside him, not behind, holding pace without hesitation. Her stride was confident, purposeful, like she knew where they were going.

He watched her in his periphery, still trying to make sense of who–what–she was. The brightness had surprised him, and he questioned how long it would last. Would she stop grinning as soon as she sensed she was far enough away from the Palace? How long would she time it before she tried to win him over or make a run for freedom? He debated whether or how he should say anything—just

some simple questions, a litmus test, to measure how deep the act went. But there was a heaviness to his tongue, a dryness in his throat, and a pull in his stomach that stopped him. No, he decided, he'd wait it out. Watch her. And in the meantime, figure out how he was going to manage the whole damn thing.

As they crossed the large square outside the Palace and closed with the beginning of the Corellian Sector, Han kept his eyes forward, continuing to watch for any opportunists, mindful that the girl all overburdened with luggage made her an easy mark. He picked up his pace instinctively, but to his surprise, she kept up without effort. No panting, no complaints, no attempt to be coddled, and no waver of her pleasant, placid expression.

They slowed at a traffic crossing before the tram station. Han checked in all directions, then stepped out. A speeder bike, haphazardly dropping from the traffic space above them at Level 12, rushed past, almost clipping both of them. Han threw an arm out, pushing the girl out of harm's way, then watched with a scowl as the bike darted through the throng of people to tightly turn at a corner.

"Fucking asshole," he griped under his breath. He checked on the girl. "You okay?"

She blinked, her face somehow bright. "I'm fine. How far to your ship?"

"We'll catch the tram, and then it's only a few minutes walk." His mouth frowned as he considered her bags again. He leaned forward, his hand reaching out. "Here, let me," he started, but she took a step back, eyeing him.

"I'm fine, thank you," she insisted graciously. "Just lead the way."

They made it onto the platform and then found a place to stand amongst the others already impatiently milling around. As it would be about a ten minute wait, she dropped her largest bag off her shoulder and let it rest at her feet, the shoulder strap dropping as well. He waited for her to quickly grab hold of it again, at least to clutch the strap in her hand, but she neglected to.

He sneered. *This is not her crowd*, he decided as explanation for her ignorance. There was something about her, too, perhaps how starry eyed she was, that told him she had little experience with being around the residents of this moon, and he covertly glanced beside him to watch her reaction. Though he expected perhaps some hesitation or fear, she instead was leisurely taking in everything around her, chin up, eyes scanning the crowd less with concern and more with pure curiosity.

He tried to make sense of that. Her enthusiasm, the hug from Deino…maybe this girl was *woikeis* but simply servant? Genuinely a favorite, a coddled position snuggly under Jiliac. Salla's derision this morning would make sense, then. This girl had influence, was used to being untouchable, at getting her way. Perhaps, he brooded, she looked at *him* and saw 'servant.'

But Deino's weighted silence, the way she'd withdrawn, like she could hold the secret close enough to her chest and obscure him from seeing. She'd have given no hesitation if something were not askew, and so large askew that her typically unflinching mien had betrayed her.

His jaw clenched again–he noticed how much his head still ached–and decided he'd already made his call and needed to just make peace with it. Chewie? The Wook would never understand. But if Han could keep the two of them apart, he could jockey well enough while together to keep the truth artfully wrapped. Besides, he might not even need to try that hard–how much could this girl want, or even enjoy, the company of a Wookiee?

She caught his eyes on her and gave him a wide smile. There was a fresh pinkness to her cheeks that livened up her fair skin, and the color only increased when she smiled. She must have taken his glance at her as an invitation, because she took a step toward him, eyebrows raised in inquisitiveness.

"So," she chirped, "have you worked for Jiliac for long?"

The question, for some reason, surprised him. "Almost a year now."

"Have you always been a pirate?"

He bristled at that label, marking again her ignorance. "No," he answered her tightly.

She waited keenly, clearly hoping he'd elaborate, but then took her cue. Just when Han believed himself in the clear, though, she piped up again. "Do you have family somewhere?"

He couldn't stop his eyes from rolling at the intrusion, though he tried to snap his head away fast enough so perhaps she didn't notice. This probing…this would prove the beginning of her either finding his soft spots or his pressure points. He'd give her nothing to cleave to and nothing to hang him with. He cleared his throat hard before turning back to give another negative.

A pause, and then in a warm, almost worried tone, "Do you have anywhere you call home?"

"No," he said with a big exhale.

She watched him a beat, seemed to register how difficult he found the topic of conversation, and visibly renewed her enthusiasm. "What's the name of your ship?"

"Doesn't have one," he answered, squinting down the tracks.

She was silent. Too silent for too long, and when he pivoted in tense curiosity, he found her brow slightly furrowed, studying him. "So you didn't rename your ship? Why? I thought all pilots did."

He slowed at the assertion, pursing his lips first before he turned back to her. "You ask a lot of questions."

At this, she balked slightly, though covered it with a smile. "I'm just making conversation."

He struggled with an inhale, forcibly trying to breathe down his frustration and find his congeniality surely buried somewhere. "It came with something I don't understand–can't read. I haven't renamed her." He shrugged, trying to offer her something. "The transponder code the Hutts gave me came with a name."

How she brightened. "Oh? What is it?"

"*Mantellian Sunrise*."

Her lips parted slightly, and her eyes scanned him like she was

waiting for something. Maybe like she thought he might say something else. When he didn't, she swallowed down her expectation. "That's a pretty name," she eventually waxed.

"I guess," he said, then he rigidly turned his attention down the tracks to check for the tram in an effort to discourage any further interrogation. Fortunately, she surrendered, and silence fell between them. Eager, then, to not accidentally initiate something else, he kept his eyes away from hers as best he could, only fleetingly glancing behind him as they got on the tram to make sure she had followed. They couldn't get to the Spacebarn soon enough.

She silently plodded beside him once they stepped off the tram and entered the mall, yet she had not disengaged entirely. Rather, she watched with an intentness every little move he made, every button he pushed, like she was marking it down for her own uses, the way a baby Massiff studies the adults to learn how to hunt. The intensity of her attention unnerved him, but anything was better than having to make small talk.

Coming off the lift, they strolled into the Spacebarn. Han waved his hellos to a couple familiar faces in the bays leading to his, and he clocked that each person's eyes shot straight past him to instead ogle at the tall creature at his side. She noticed the attention, too, smiling confidently at everyone who would meet her gaze. He snarked: this girl was going to get eaten alive.

As they finally entered Bay 7, Han's attention did a quick sweep around the space. The gangplank was up, which surprised him. "Chewie?" he called out into the stillness. He waited for the delayed ruffle of his copilot, but the only noise that met him was his echo. He tried again, confused now. Still no answer.

The girl intently studied the contents of the docking bay before turning inquisitive eyes to him. "Is everyone else here a friend?"

He couldn't help a snark at her attempt. "Nobody around here makes friends," he answered dryly, his thumbs punching in the access code. The gangplank lowered with a characteristic heavy clicking, and

he watched it closely, forgetting about his company for a second while he kept his ear craned for any issues. They'd tinkered with it yesterday afternoon, double checking fluid levels and trying to grease the myriad shafts. To his satisfaction, it finished without complication.

"Well, that's certainly not true," she parried, correcting him and yet somehow alluring.

"This place ain't friendly like that." He did not curb his patronizing tone. "Everybody's out for themselves." And then he watched her, curious to see her response, wondering if she could be provoked to show her hand.

Again, she gave that charming smile, and her dark orbs shimmered. "I think it's more complicated than that," she suggested. "Salla Zend?"

At that, Han's expression fell off his face, followed immediately by a scowl as a defensive anger boiled up from his stomach. "How do you know about Salla?!"

There was a coyness to her smile. "She flies for the Desilijic, too, sometimes. I've seen her. And I hear enough of the pirate gossip." She glanced Han up and down. "She's–"

"A little rough around the edges, I know," he said, cutting her off. That she was older than him by at least ten years was also surely part of the gossip, but he left that part out. It didn't bother him any, and he wasn't sure why so many people latched onto it. "But she's good company."

Her coyness shifted to impishness, the twinkle in her eye unmistakable. "I was going to say, she's an excellent pilot. I've heard she rivals you."

The irritation melted, and he smirked to cover the fluster at his miscalculation. "She'd love nothing more than to hear you say that," he tossed out the side of his mouth. "It's not *true*, but–"

He was going to add some other snarky remark, but a bark from the bay entrance filled the space and took her attention with it. Han watched Chewie close the distance with his lumbering gait, his focus stubbornly fixated on the girl as he approached. He finally came

to a stop beside them, towering over both humans as he did most sentients, but met gentle eyes with the guest.

Dismissing the thread of his conversation with the girl, Han gestured to the Wookiee. "This here's Chewbacca, my copilot. Chewie, this is–" Han halted, waiting for the word to come. A few seconds passed, and he cringed–he'd forgotten her name!

She extended her hand out–had she noticed?–and Chewie accepted it eagerly. "Korë Cali. Nice to meet you, Chewbacca."

Chewie cooed in response, offering up his nickname for her use and apologizing in advance for his unruly friend and pilot. Han rolled his eyes: he'd edit that last bit out of his translation.

"Oh, quite the contrary," she responded before Han could even open his mouth. "Captain Solo has been polite so far."

Either to her proficiency or her rebuttal, Chewie paused in surprise but only for a moment. [*Give him time*] he quipped. [*He'll disappoint soon enough*.]

Han wasn't sure who to respond to first, but found himself turning alarmed eyes to the girl. "You speak Shyriiwook?!"

"I have remnants of it locked away from school," she answered with a puckish air, then returned her warm eyes to Chewie. "If you'll indulge me, I'd love to find out just how much I retained."

Charmed, the Wookiee purred at her and started a response.

Han gawked for a beat. What a wrench in his plans! Keeping them apart–silent–would prove much more difficult than he realized.

He found his voice again and shooed at the both of them. "We don't have time for this," he asserted, gesturing up the open gangplank.

The girl blinked at him in mild surprise, but with a genial grin at Chewie, followed the order and started into the ship.

"'Disappoint soon enough' eh? I heard that," Han growled once she was out of earshot.

[*Good*] Chewie snipped back. [*I figured I'd give her fair warning*.] He paused for a moment, letting the zinger marinate first. [*What did you learn*?]

Though instinctively, he wanted to turn his chin away, to find some excuse to break eye contact, Han instead stared harder. Shrugged his shoulder as his lips folded over. "Not much. Quick hand off."

[*They said nothing? No instructions, no duration*?]

Han tutted. "Deino was cagey, but that's normal. She gave me a navigator," he added, only remembering it as he said it aloud. "Landing pad already selected. Even booked a hotel. Nice part of town."

[*And the girl*?]

This, Han could not answer, not even with his best sabacc straight face. He turned away enough, reaching in for the navigator as he did so, wincing. "Nothing extra. Just said to make it back safe."

Chewie grumbled, shifting his weight on his feet while he thought. [*I don't like this*.]

Han was thumbing through the navigator screen, ostensibly checking to see if there was anything else he had missed. "I don't much, either. Would have preferred just a regular job." He stuffed the navigator back in his pocket with his mouth askew. "Let's just make this as smooth as possible. Just relax."

[*Damn you, how are we supposed to just 'just relax'*?!]

"She went to school," Han countered. "Knows Shyriiwook. Does that sound like a slave to you?"

[*I went to schoo–*]

"Yeah, but you're a hundred." An exaggeration, but his point stood. "Look, she walked here of her own freewill, smiling the whole damn time. She's *excited*, far as I can tell. You're winding yourself up over nothing."

[*It's not* ***nothing***!] Chewie snarled, looming forward over his captain.

Han didn't break. "Get in the cockpit and get everything started," he finally managed, his voice low, then walked ahead of the Wook into the ship.

The girl was waiting for him just inside when he ascended the

gangplank. He strolled past, barely acknowledging her, only to halt in embarrassment at the disarray of the corridors and the tight lounge area. He'd meant to do something about it–he didn't especially like having an unkempt space–but there'd been so many other tasks…

He gestured to what little there was to see. "It'll be about a five, maybe six hour trip into the Core, so," he paused, regretting needing to say it, "make yourself comfortable."

She eyed him skeptically. "Six hours?"

A better ship could have done it in three, and he bristled to be reminded. He sucked in a breath to curb his tongue, but she gave him a small smile before he could say anything.

"Actually, I've been looking forward to this trip. All the uninterrupted time is an opportunity for me to work on a lot of small details. I hope you don't think I'm rude, but I'll likely keep to my quarters."

He tried not to appear too relieved. "No, of course. I'm sure you have a lot to do."

He walked her down another narrow corridor, moving a few bins of electrical equipment and tools out of the way. He brought her to a bunk room at the back that they'd mostly used for storage. There was seating somewhere in there underneath all the junk.

"Sorry I don't have a better spot to offer you," Han professed as she stepped into the cramped and disheveled room. "If it's too messy, you can give me a few minutes and I'll pick up."

She dropped her things and met kind eyes with him. "This is fine, Captain Solo. It's just fine."

He forced a smile but couldn't hold it for very long. "Well. We're just about ready to take off, so if you strap yourself in, we'll get going."

He couldn't get out of there fast enough and quickly crossed to the cockpit. As commanded, Chewie was already in, headset on and talking to the navicomputer and ATC. Han slid in beside him, eager to get busy with his half of the pre-flight checks. They worked in silence, only exchanging as much as necessary to get the 'Suub in the air. Still,

Han waited for the Wookiee at some point to say more, to press harder, to throw some kind of fit to needle more of the truth out of him. However, neither caved, and Han let himself get consumed in his task.

Finally content that everything appeared in working order, he gave out the command to fire up the engines, and the ship lifted ungracefully and began the exit out of the hangar. Once in the atmosphere, he increased speed, which the ship shuddered familiarly to, and within a few minutes, they broke past the exosphere. Han checked the timer on the nav–he only had a few seconds remaining–and held his breath as he pulled down on the lever.

…nothing happened. The pinpricks of light around them *should* have lengthened into long rods before twisting into the familiar vortex, but *nothing happened*. Instead, he could hear the hyperdrive straining–that is, until the timer on the nav ran out and started firing alerts in a rapid, irritating beep.

"What is she doing?" Han yelped, trying to check systems on his half of the instrument panel. Nothing in particular catching his eye, he whirled around to face his copilot. "What is she doing?!"

[*I don't know*!] Chewie snarled back, flipping through screens.

Still the hyperdrive whined, struggling with something. Han ran through all the possible explanations. None of his sensors were coming back that the hyperdrive itself was faulty–it was like she was having difficulty in pulling fuel.

He gasped. The valves.

Chewie must have come to the same conclusion at the same time, and his resulting roar made Han's ears ring. [*I told you not to use those damn parts! She already has enough janked pieces on her!*]

"What else was I gonna do?" Han raged back. "*Not* take those parts?! This fucking ship's outdated, *everything* that we find for her is secondhand or bootleg!"

[*We're gonna blow up right here–we're atom dust–and it's because of* **you**!] At that, Chewie whimpered, then whined out some Wookiee prayers in speech so quick even Han couldn't decipher.

As his first mate slipped into a panic, Han swiftly took stock of his predicament. Chewie was right: a half-charged hyperdrive with no output could short-circuit, and the short-circuit would destabilize the hyperdrive core, and that was bad. *Really* bad.

"I'm gonna cut it off," he decided, hands scrambling across the controls. He still had time to interrupt this. He could put a stop to the hyperdrive motivator, let the whole mechanism cool down and have the charge drain out, run diagnostics, then try again. Sometimes she was fussy like that, just needed to try things a second or third time, and she'd get it right. It was fine, he reassured himself shakily–it was going to be fine.

His hand reached for the lever and he was a second from unengaging when he was violently flung back and sideways in his seat. Chewie let out a startled roar, and then the whining of the engine stopped, the blaring of the navicomputer halted. The cockpit went silent.

Disoriented, Han tried to get his bearings, his hand reaching for his chest. *Am I dead? Was that it?* Then his vision cleared, and it registered to him that out the view window, he was staring at a swirl of blue and white.

His eyes slowly panned over to Chewie, who had also gone still. Silently, they exchanged wide-eyed glances. That shouldn't have worked. The nav had already timed out. A ship wasn't supposed to make a jump without coordinates.

He swallowed hard before he dared ask. "What does it say?" he mustered, his voice quiet, eyeballing the nav readout on the far right of the panel. Already, he feared the worst: getting stuck in between hyperspace and realspace was allegedly an awful way to go.

Chewie read it, then his head tilted, and Han watched him consider it again. The Wookiee trilled softly, humored. [*Terminus at Randon. Same coordinates as we put in.*]

At that, Han sunk in his seat with a groan, head buried in his hands. "This *fucking* ship."

* * *

He wiped the sweat off his brow with the back of a gloved hand. The assurances he'd tried to offer himself hadn't really landed. Yes, the error had not repeated itself so far. That didn't mean it still couldn't.

The 'Suub, in her truest colors, of course had not repeated her hiccup at the other two junctions; they'd come out of hyperspace and reentered just fine. Exiting now, finally at Esseles, also should be fine. He *wanted* to believe that they'd come out of hyperspace smoothly, that nothing too goofy would happen in their attempt to transition. They had already run what analytics they could on her, trying to troubleshoot exactly what had caused the lag, but the ship's computer kept spitting back the same unhelpful answers. They needed to make it to their destination and finally be on solid ground to get eyeballs on the ship's system to pinpoint the error.

Hand on the hyperdrive controls, his breath caught in his throat. *Please*, he begged, *just cooperate*.

Blue and white fell away into a familiar black peppered with flecks of light. Far ahead of them awaited a lone planet covered in a mossy green and ringed by a small, translucent tiara of ice.

The tension in the cockpit eased, and Han let go of a nervous laugh. "See, I knew she could do it," he announced, turning smugly to his copilot. "You're always such a worrywart."

Chewie shot an annoyed glance at him but said nothing.

"Okay, now to touch down," Han continued to himself, flying them steady and doing his utmost to keep his routine. Nervousness still sent tingling electricity down his forearms. Not anxiety at the ship–that manifested as pure irritation–but instead at the planet, this nexus. The Core. This was the closest he'd been to it in damn near three years. How long ago that was, yet somehow just like yesterday.

His attention was abruptly stolen by an alarm from the radar. He silenced the noise, and the both of them turned their eyes up to the vector ahead, acknowledging the cruiser that crouched in the distance.

Chewie began an apprehensive whine, an instinctive response to the proximity of the juggernaut.

"Sorosuub *Starmite*, Key 102558, state destination and intention," came a voice over the from the Star Destroyer.

"Don't worry, I got this," Han insisted quietly to Chewie before turning on his comm. "This is *Starmite* 102558, en route to Calamar, Sector 9, landing pad 21. Headed to Esseles for…" And then he hesitated–he realized he didn't need to fib. The Empire would have no qualms with their business here: Esseles was a top destination for many in the arts, and recruiters regularly came from all over the galaxy to scalp people back out to the farthest reaches. This was, in some ways, the most normal trip he'd agreed to in a long time.

"Headed to Esseles to deliver a shipment of *isfa* gourds," he answered before he could stop himself, then rolled his eyes. He *literally* could have named anything else.

In response, the other end sat silent for too many beats, and Han frowned. *Please don't ask questions, please don't ask questions*, he implored.

"*Mantellian Sunrise*, proceed on course to landing pad 21," the voice answered back.

Han was quick to confirm. *Didn't even need to lie*, he admonished, then forced a laugh. Habit.

The exchange wasn't over just quite yet. "All hail to the Empire," the voice offered as close.

At that, Han froze, not simply at the words themselves, though they were not easy to hear. They expected him to say it back.

He remained still for a few moments, stiff at the onus of having to repeat the phrase, before he finally remembered himself. He passed regretful eyes over his copilot before his finger reached out again for the comm. He licked his lips then pushed the button down, only to find that his breath was hanging in his throat, somehow unable to move past his lips. He'd just have to manage. "All hail to the Empire," he forced out, his voice slightly breaking mid-sentence.

The Star Destroyer said nothing else, and Han hastily engaged

thrusters before they changed their mind. He could feel the weight in the cockpit, however, and fleetingly glanced beside him. Chewie was working, his attention attuned to the various inputs across his numerous keys and screens, but the cheerless disposition was evident in his movements.

"Sorry," Han tossed out. "I had to."

The Wookiee said nothing but nodded, and the two of them turned their attention to the ever-growing blue-green world before them.

As they broke atmosphere and cut through a wispy haze of clouds, the capital spread before them. Calamar sat on a scalloped coastline. Broad bays bit into the land, headlands lifted into evergreen hills, and neighborhoods stepped down toward the water in terraces of stone, glass, and hanging gardens. The city swayed green and blue and white, punctuated occasionally by the riot of purples from the native Picarra bushes. As they neared, even the transit looked organic—funiculars and cliffside lifts eased from hilltop gardens to quay-level promenades where low-flying clippers stitched white lines across the bay.

Landing pad 21 turned out to be a private slip, quite elegantly concealed on the side of a taller tower, complete with a clamshell gate. He'd have missed it completely if not for the gray, gaping mouth of the hangar standing in such stark contrast to the sleek white limestone of its neighboring structures. He guided her in, attentive to each small adjustment, particularly careful to make no abrupt move and break anything–on the ship as much as the hangar. Finally, he centered the ship within the yellow markings of the floor, and the *Starmite* eased down, her landing gear audibly and satisfactorily obliging. At least something on her worked right.

The clamshell drew shut behind them with a low hydraulic hum, slicing the pad off from the city's breeze. Lights along the deck blinked from amber to steady white. One by one, they powered down the *Starmite*'s systems. The ship wheezed and popped and cracked as she settled, and Han craned his ear through each noise, listening for a

wrong tone and, blessedly, not hearing any.

[*Now what*?] Chewie asked, strained and trying to hide it.

Han thumbed the exterior cams onto the forward screen. The slip was tidy: a polished, almost shiny deck, recessed tool lockers, a discreet security bead in each corner. He watched the door at the far side in anxious anticipation, and out the corner of his eye, he could see the shaggy figure beside him doing the same, his large frame tilted forward. A minute ticked by. Then another.

Han sat back, shutting off the cameras. "If anyone was coming, they would have by now. The Hutts own this, or someone they know does, so I don't think we gotta worry about being bothered in here. You should be fine to walk around the pad–just keep the door closed." He grimaced for a moment with another thought. "And if anybody does come in here creepin'–shoot 'em. We'll figure it out later."

[*And you*?]

He waved the question away. "Don't worry about me. You worry about that damn hyperdrive. Figure out what made her short out like that, and let me know as soon as you do. I'll keep in touch," he finished as he got up from his seat. Chewie, in turn, rumbled a goodbye.

He stopped in his bunkroom first, reaching for his satchel with an automatic swipe, then stopped, remembering himself. His pistol…it would have to stay on the ship. There could be no striding around the upper levels with it, and he wouldn't risk bringing trouble onto himself if caught with something smaller and concealed. "Do one illegal thing at a time," Shrike had warned him long ago, maybe one of the few pieces of advice that had actually proven useful. Still, it'd been a while since he'd been naked like that in public. He heaved a sigh as his hands found the buckle at his knee.

Methodically, he worked to unstrap himself, and in the quiet, the anxiety flared again. He was going to have to walk out there. Be near them. Overhear their chatter and the commands and not flinch…or freak out. He'd need to keep his head screwed on tight.

Swallow down his vitriol and conceal his dread. They were out there scanning for whoever seemed too nervous, too aware of their presence; he'd put a target on his head if he couldn't stroll down the street like he belonged as much as any other damn sop.

Same as every other trip, he coached himself as he laid his gun and holster across his bunk. With resolve, he forced the feelings back down. His chin tucked, his brow set, a hardness settled into his shoulders. That was something Shrike had taught him, too, to be afraid and not show it. To wear a mask of indifference and even spiteful humor in the face of harm. To grit through all kinds of pain.

He made for the spare bunkroom in heavy steps. His mouth opened to call the girl's name, but he found he'd forgotten it again. Something-Cali. Instead, he loudly announced his presence, shouting at the door that it was time to depart. No answer met him. He waited for another second, then called again. Again, nothing. His fist rapped at the door–not aggressive, just strong enough to shake the metal bulkhead. When he heard nothing back, he opened the door and found the cabin empty. Cleaned, for sure–she'd organized everything into neat piles and made room for herself–but empty.

A knot formed at his throat. *Not already–fuck, not this quick.* Exasperated, Han turned on his heel, eyes darting around into all the little corners and storage rooms. She could hide, he reasoned; hide and wait for him to chase after her, then…hell, educated as she was, she could probably pilot. She could plead her case to Chewie and only need to get five words in: he'd leave the ship to her in a heartbeat. The big sap. The fool.

Maybe she'd already beat him there. Pivoting, he took long strides to start for the cockpit, and in doing so, stepped into the lounge. As soon as he cleared the corner, he halted, his chest seizing at the sight of light streaming in from the lowered gangplank.

He was too late. She'd dashed already. Gone.

His head slowly craned in the direction of the cockpit. Anger churned low in his gut, a steaming heat that was more brimstone and spittle than lexical. That *fucking* Wookiee.

He took a step toward the cockpit, readying to unleash all his rage on his copilot, and then caught a flickering at the corner of his eye. Instinctively, he turned to check and realized it was shadow. As he watched, the light from the gangplank fractured again, then a third time, though in that instance less so.

Someone was pacing in the bay, he realized. Going for his weapon was his first impulse–he'd not want to meet anyone without protection. But then he caught the shape of the shadow, or maybe, it materialized into something like a silhouette. He panted out his disbelief, slowly crossing the lounge to verify. He halted again at the top of the gangplank as the sight before him registered.

"It's nice to stretch my legs," she started. "I spent too long working all crumpled up."

He played with his tongue in his cheek as he toyed with how sharp to cut. "Got Chewie to lower the plank for you?" he asked, as much a mocking as a question.

She stopped, her eyes slightly wide in surprise. "Chewie? Oh, I thought you did. I thought you were telling me to come out."

Han turned his head away in a laugh that was all bitter sarcasm. Chewie had dropped the plank; he'd given her the out. Testing her…and his honesty. Shaking his head, like that might make the acrid taste at the back of his mouth dissolve, he shrugged his bag up on his shoulder and took heavy steps down the gangplank.

"Are you ready?" she asked brightly, having missed his derisive grunt. In anticipation of his affirmative, a device appeared in her hand. Matte pink, fat and cylindrical, and only about the size of her palm, she brought it close to her face and softly called out a command. A white light spun at the droid's top edge, then a hologram of a map sprang up. "Looks like we're only a subsection over from the theater and the hotel," she said quietly, almost to herself. "Should probably only be about a fifteen, twenty minute walk. Wanna see?" she asked, lifting the device and its map toward him.

Mouth askew, he lifted out the navigator Deino had given him from his shirt's breast pocket and flashed it at her. On his own, he

pulled up the map and made quick sense of it. She was right–they needed only to walk down the main corridor about a half a kilometer, then take a left and walk another two hundred paces. The theater and hotel were separate, but only a few minute's walk apart.

"The local time is still fairly early," she continued, chipper, apparently unfazed by his antipathy, "but it's my understanding that they'll accommodate me for the check-in time. We won't have to wait." Pleased with herself, she started to pick up her bags and organize them across her person.

"What exactly is your schedule like?"

She shrugged a shoulder before hoisting another bag over it. "I'm not sure of the specifics. Deino was in contact with someone here who's been organizing everything. I believe maybe as soon as tomorrow, auditions will begin, but I won't know until I can get settled and make contact." She huffed, a flutter of overwhelm that she immediately covered with a grin. "I just want into my room first, and then I can sort everything out." She looked over Han's shoulder at the ship. "I assume that Chewie's staying?"

"Uh…yeah. Yeah. Not too smart for him to be walking around here."

She nodded in understanding. "I'm surprised he came with."

His eyes narrowed. "What does that mean?" he asked, more growl in his voice than he meant.

She withdrew, though only ever so slightly. "Nothing, I just meant–I understand that it's risky." Her eyes settled on him, a wistful warmth in her gaze. "You guys must be a tight crew."

At that, he couldn't help but part snarl, part laugh at her. "Listen–he's…*fine*. You worry about you. Keep your eyes ahead, don't gawk at anything or anybody, and certainly don't squirm underneath any Imperial attention. Anybody else, you tell 'em the truth, least as much of it that won't result in any unwanted questions." He paused them, exhaling hard through his nose in strain as he scrutinized her. "And another thing," he started again, reaching for the largest bag on her shoulder, "don't carry all these like this. It's too easy to pick a

pocket or two, because you have so many." Having balanced the load, he walked around her. "And stay on my left side."

She heard him, he knew, because she studied him with that alert regard. Yet, in silence, she merely turned away. Not irritated, not flippant, just…he might as well have told her that the sky was blue or water was wet for all she cared. She strolled to the lift and requested a stop, though when he joined her before the doors, she fell in line beside him as he'd demanded, eyes forward and expression inscrutable.

Blinding white light and a wash of cool air, minerally and fresh, hit them as the lift doors opened. Han flinched, scowling on instinct, a hand coming up to shade his eyes. He hovered there a moment, adjusting, recalibrating, then managed to drop his hand and squint into the sunlight. He registered then that she'd already stepped on, right to the edge of the car, her hands grasping the railing as she took in the scene before her.

They were high—halfway up the tower's flank where the lift track ran along an exterior rib—and the city unfurled below in terraces and light. Calamar didn't sprawl so much as cascade. Blocks of pale limestone stepped toward the water like giant bleachers, each tier a band of green. Glassy footbridges stitched tower to tower, their railings crowded with potted herbs and hanging lanterns. Between rooftops, narrow rills threaded along the stone, catching sun in quicksilver runs and whispering down into little circular pools that winked blue in the light. Far off, gulls wheeled above a shimmering inlet; closer, the low chime of a civic bell hopped from plaza to plaza, its echo softened by leaves.

Han stepped out behind her, boots thudding once against the lift's deck. The girl didn't move. Even from behind, he could read it: how enamored she was, how still in the face of the sweeping detail, the shimmering off the blue inlet below, how extra high and far away the sky felt. For a moment, he wilted with a twinge of sympathy. He, too, could remember being young and stepping onto this world that seemed like a paradise, a living painting of detail and sentiment.

Hope, even…just something light and dreamy that made everything prior melt away into insignificance.

"Careful near the edge," he advised.

She swiveled and took him in, surprised, disoriented, then laughed slightly at herself. "Sorry," she offered, and then she started to take a step away, but her eyes found the horizon again and it pulled her back in. She continued to watch as the lift began its descent, each level revealing additional detail.

"Real different from Nar Shaddaa, huh?"

She was slow to answer, but creaked out an affirmative. "I haven't breathed in fresh air in a long time," she eventually said, then met Han's gaze to give him a small smile. This time she pivoted her torso, stepping back from the edge, her head inclined. "Have you ever been to Esseles before?"

His jaw clenched at the question. He glanced out over the biophilic metropolis. Nothing looked familiar. "No," he lied, then paused, curious if she'd press further. Though she didn't, she still stared. Unnerved by her silent attention, he returned the volley. "I'd guess you neither, yeah?"

She let go of a dry pant. "I haven't been very many places." Her eyes dropped then, and she turned back out to further study the square below them.

An Esselian customs officer waited for them as they came to the plaza entrance at the ground floor. Han tugged at the girl to stay behind him. She obeyed. The officer didn't say much as he examined their IDs, then handed them back with a forced smile. Han tightly nodded, nudging the girl to head for the exit. Though she walked, her focus was slow to leave the officer, and Han followed her line of sight to the gun at his hip.

As they cleared his earshot, Han gestured with a tilt of his head. "You ever shoot one of those?"

"A blaster? No," she said frankly.

He frowned. "Well, what about in your club? What if someone is a problem?"

"It's my policy to always try diplomacy first," she lilted.

Han raised his brow at her skeptically. "And when one of those customers can't be charmed?"

She gave him her own self-satisfied smile. "I can take care of myself, Captain Solo."

He scrutinized her doubtfully. She neared his height and was of a medium build. He wouldn't say she was weak, but to assert she was strong enough to fight off anyone larger than her was foolish. Curious now, he studied her further. She had an accent he couldn't place, and those dark features on the light skin could mean she came from practically anywhere. He couldn't discern her age. She looked young but didn't carry herself that way; she had a cool confidence that normally came with years. Regardless, there was youth in those eyes–foolish, optimistic, untested youth–and he snarked to remember back to his own unearned, brash confidence. His had been a survival mechanism; there would have been no staying alive without it. Hers seemed needless.

Exiting to the street, Han strolled through the sliding glassine doors of the lobby, then…slowed, almost to a stop. An odd pulling tugged at the back of his head, a nagging sense of something wrong. The pulling turned into a prickle, and then angst rippled down his arms, turning his hairs painfully on end.

His awareness–always at attention–dialed all the way up, and his eyes darted around, anxiously trying to make out what could warrant such a reaction. He took in the avenue before him: pale limestone facades stepped in graceful tiers; balconies braided in greenery; a canal whispering along a beveled curb while pedestrians drifted by at an unhurried clip. He found nothing particularly jarring about that, and he craned his ear, wondering if he'd picked up noise of scuffle or conflict. But the longer he stood there, straining to identify some unmistakable threat, he realized his error.

Subconsciously, he'd been expecting a replica of Coruscant, that Calamar would be a city heavily draped in Imperial regalia, its streets so closely and aggressively monitored by Imperial patrols that

this place that he'd experienced as leisurely had been squelched into something barren and dour. Or that it had been polished into the upper levels of the Imperial Capital, with everything a bit too clean, too sterile, in a manner that belied the atrocities that some of its most exclusive members not only condoned but ordered. But this scene before him…it looked so recognizable. So much the same, and yet, he could *feel* that it wasn't. They were there, he gauged, in the crowd. Checkpoints disguised as concierge kiosks. A "neighborhood ward" booth with an Imperial seal so faint it might be a watermark. Planters that were really bollards. And, almost blending in against the creamy limestone buildings, the white, faceless mask of a statuesque stormtrooper posted every fifteen meters.

He balked, breathless at how pervasive it all felt. Rapidly, he reassessed his calculus. Was this really the same? Could he distinguish between Esselian and Imp? What businesses could he perhaps find refuge in, what alley might not have a camera? He shrank, suddenly uncomfortable in his own skin. What they had done to this place in such a short time…

"Is everything okay?"

Her voice broke him from his daze, and he hastily pulled himself together. She had stepped ahead of him a few paces, and he shifted his weight to face her, opening his mouth to answer, then caught himself again. *So that's why*, he now grasped: those bright eyes, that almost-smile, the lean figure that stood with poise, the cadence to her voice that lent it a charming, almost sing-songy quality at times, the uncalled-for politeness, and the cool, unearned confidence. This girl had no place on Nar Shaddaa, but *this*? This looked exactly like where she belonged.

"Fine," he answered gruffly, pushing out ahead of her. He kept his eyes on the map for the duration of their walk, eager to not allow her an opening to talk or a passing stranger too long a chance to get a look at him. Following course, they passed the theater–a small place with two sets of carved and gilded double doors–then continued down the walkway to the hotel. 'Malden Hall' read the durasteel sign

in thin, black font, and they slipped past a preoccupied doordroid to enter the lobby.

Once inside, it was her turn to direct him to wait. He obliged, though not without a grimace, finding a place out of the way to stand. Once planted, he bounced his attention around the lobby, ostensibly observing the architecture and furnishings of the space, but really keeping track of who else was there and where and why and how many eyeballs he had on him.

After a few sweeps that assuaged his paranoia, his eyes restlessly found the girl again. She was smile-laughing; apparently, the human man helping her at the concierge desk had said something particularly amusing…or she was good at making him think he had. The man prattled back at her, grinning large himself, and Han eyerolled at their schmoozing.

Finally having finished at the desk, she started down another large hallway and beckoned him to follow. He caught up, still irked at how effectively she could wield her charm. As he closed, his eyes narrowed. "You get a lot done with that pretty face, huh?"

He had meant it to be provocative, and she cocked her head back to take him in first. He would swear he would have caught if her eyes had narrowed or lips had pursed. But still, despite her lack of movement, something about her *shifted*. With a blink, the difference was gone, and the smile returned. "I won't deny that a pretty face gives me a leg up–"

"'Leg up' is putting it mildly," he mocked.

"–but you'd be surprised how far you can get with a smile." She tilted her head suggestively. "Maybe you should try smiling more."

He snorted at her naivete. "It's a good way to get taken advantage of."

"*No*, it keeps your options open," she insisted. "You can always walk in friendly and see where that goes, then get mad. You can't go in the other direction; it's insincere and people don't like that."

They found an interior lift that they took with a handful of other people, though they stepped out to their floor alone. Confidently, she directed them to a room, then punched in a code. The door slid open, revealing a small room with a single bed, a vid unit, a refresher, and a settee. Entering, she pulled her bags off her shoulders and rested them on the couch, directing Han to do the same.

He obliged, but slowly, confused. "Where's the other room?"

She had already walked into the refresher to inspect it and wandered out. "There is no other room," she responded, distracted in her exploration.

Hairs prickled at the back of his neck again. "We're not both staying in here, are we?!"

"Of course we aren't," she laughed. "You and Chewbacca are to stay on your ship."

He scowled. "How in the hell am I supposed to keep an eye on you from there?! You're gonna have me shuffle back and forth all day every day to escort you? That's a bunch of shit."

At this, she paused and met his gaze, her eyes widened in calculated surprise. "An escort?" she breathed, somehow both sensual and condescending. "Who said anything about an escort? I needed transport here, not a warden."

Han's back went rigid. Maybe he hadn't been given explicit instructions, but his gut churned with apprehension. "That's not what I was told," he said tightly.

"I was all of a few steps away, Captain Solo," she mused. "Deino never specified that you were to hover over me."

His eyes narrowed. He wondered–suspected–how much she'd heard. How much she knew. No way this was innocent ignorance; some part of her was toying with him. But how much…and to what end? "But you don't think it's a good idea?" he probed.

"I think it's a needless idea. You saw the walk here–I'm perfectly fine."

He sucked in a breath, thinking. How to 'hover' without sitting too close and giving his anxiety away? "I'd feel better to keep

an eye on you myself," he settled on, then gave her his lopsided smile–maybe charm would work on her. "You gave me the impression you were going to be agreeable."

He realized his miscalculation as her smile disappeared and her jaw set. "I'm being incredibly agreeable. You successfully delivered me here. Now all you need to do is twiddle your thumbs or tinker with your ship or go to the bar–or whatever it is you do to kill time while you're planetside–until I let you know that we can go back to Nar Shaddaa. This trip will be the easiest money you ever made." She held out her hand, palm flat. "I'd like my ID."

His blood began to boil. Deino had warned him not to do anything stupid, and he thought she'd essentially been telling him to keep his manhood to himself. Ruefully, he realized she had been telling him to resist strangling the girl.

She must have noticed his brewing agitation, as she dropped her hand. "If you want a reason to hang around here, there's a complimentary breakfast in the morning. You could always join me for it." There was a lyrical quality to the way she said it that made it clear she was mocking him.

"No," Han challenged, stepping forward, "you're not gonna push me aside like that. Listen, dammit, maybe you don't understand what exactly is on the line here, so let me explain this to you! *You*," he emphasized, finger pointing hard at her, "answer to the Hutts. *I*," he thrust his thumb in his chest, "work for those Hutts. Now, I don't give a damn what happens to you after this trip. Soon as we're back, you do whatever it is your little heart desires. Do your damn little project. Fuck off. Get swallowed up by the Smuggler's Moon–I don't care. But *right now*, it's my job to get you back to Nar Shaddaa in one piece. That's what I'm being paid for, that's what the Hutts are expecting, and that's what I mean to do. Now, Esseles is a big damn place, lots of little *nooks and crannies* to get lost or hide in, and dammit, I am not gonna to end up on the chopping block because you hightailed it out of here!"

He paused for a moment to take a breath, and he watched her

mouth open to answer him, but the curve of her lip tipped him off that whatever she was about to say was just another irritating attempt at charming her way out of this.

Impulsively, he rushed her. "No, don't you dare!" he shouted, pointing his finger in her face again. "Don't you dare give me another lippy answer! You and that fucking mouth!" He hovered before her, braced for a torrent of colorful language to rebut him. *Bring it, dammit, I* dare *you!* he baited, staring her down.

Her attention fixated on the index finger accusing her, staring hard at it, then her eyes flickered up to his. The roundness of her eyes–so playful and bright–had abruptly shifted into a feline, tapered shape, with heavier lids and peaked brows. And behind her eyes, suddenly, there was a sharpness, a *knowing*, that Han hadn't caught before. The expression would have been alluring if it weren't so…predatory. Unconsciously, he recoiled, keen to put space between them.

She studied Han, penetrating him with that gaze, considering something. With a blink, her eyes softened, then she straightened her back, chin lifting as well. "My objective here is as stated–I intend to hold auditions to fill out my line up. Nothing more." She assessed him again, dressing him down with her shrewd glare, and his mouth went dry. "I'm not out to make trouble for you, Captain Solo."

He chewed on that for a moment, still seething. Finally, he found his words. "You don't have to make trouble for trouble to happen."

Those tapered eyes shimmered with humor, which irritated him more: how could she think this was funny?!

"Don't tell me you really believe that Jiliac would send me here without as much insurance as he can muster?" She smirked sardonically. "The pad you landed on was Hutt-owned. The theater, this hotel–most of this whole block–is Hutt-owned. Deino expects me to make daily reports out to them, but I suspect they have eyes on me here, likely even as we speak," she said as she gestured at the room. "They've got me on a credit slip to track all of my purchases and my

whereabouts. And you have to know they have every single one of my biomarkers. No, Captain Solo, I don't need you to babysit me."

He weighed that for a beat. "Larsen watches you," Han rebutted. "Right under the Hutts' noses."

The girl shook her head, a smidge dismissively, like one might do to a child who made a silly mistake. "Larsen escorts me because Nar Shaddaa is dangerous. Esseles is not dangerous, at least not like that." Her eyes then shot out the window to the view of the city. "Not that the Imps are much reassurance. Just…marsh pigs in polished boots."

Though it killed him that he did it, he couldn't help slightly but recoil. In her simmering, though, she did not notice.

"And besides," she continued, turning back to him, "I know I'm being tested."

"*Tested?* Tested for what?"

"Trustworthiness," she answered flatly, then half-rolled her eyes. "Obedience, if we're being honest. But it's more palatable when they call it trust. It's not my first test, and it won't be the last. I intend to pass."

There was an earnestness to the way she answered, the way she could hold his gaze as she did it. If she were a liar, she was a pretty damn good one.

He studied her, pensive, still acutely aware of the waver in his chest, the voice that urged him to be cautious. Suspicious. He shifted his weight around, back and forth, considering. It could be his neck if anything happened to her–Deino had made that mighty clear–but the truth was he wanted nothing more than to get out of this. The 'Suub likely needed repairs before they lifted off, and he was the only one of his crew with the ability to walk around to drum up parts if they needed it. And Chewie…he was a better mechanic than him, Han could concede that, but the Wookiee had no damn practical sense when it came to priorities. The ship's engine would end up utterly disassembled if Han left him alone.

Yeah, he'd have to give her space, room on the leash, but not

too much. He'd tail her tonight and tomorrow, monitor her whereabouts. Make sure she did what she said she'd do. He'd have to come up with something to tell Chewie, to keep the Wook from questioning his disappearances when there was a ship to fiddle with, but he'd figure something out.

"Fine," he conceded with a grimace, "I'll make you a deal: you will give me your location–"

"Already done," she interrupted. "Check your navigator. It's linked to Rosie."

"To Rosie?" he questioned with a squint.

Wordlessly, she turned to one of her satchels and rifled through it, quickly locating her item. She spun, holding it out for display. In her flat palm sat that fat, cylindrical pink comm.

Skeptical, Han pulled the nav piece back out. Sure enough, her location pin overlapped with his.

"But you could leave it anywhere," he countered.

She panted a laugh, her smile wide and genuine as she tossed the comm on the bed. "I *could*, but I wouldn't. I'd be lost without Rosie."

He dryly grinned at her, hardly humored by her answer. How easy it came. He clocked how nervous that made him. He hated, too, he could read on her face that she knew she'd been convincing.

Regardless, with an exhale, he finally capitulated, and fished out her ID to hand over. She reached for it. He almost let her touch it, but at the last second, he snapped it out of her grip, eyeing her. "I'm still gonna come check on you."

That time, her eye twitched. Not much, but enough that it took her a half-second to recover. "Check as often as you like," she replied smoothly. "I'll be at the theater by seven in the morning. But I will not have my movement restricted according to your schedule. I know you are used to running cargo, Captain Solo, but I am not an object to be ferried about."

He hesitated for a beat, relishing a little to see the slightest bit of impatience at the downturned corners of her mouth, then slowly

lowered his arm. She plucked the ID from his hand, then placed it on the bedside table. She kept her back to him, turning her attention to her bags as she began to sort through them with deliberate calm.

He raised his brows–apparently, he'd been dismissed. He waited for a bit longer, curious if she'd acknowledge him eventually, but she remained consumed in her task. He shifted on his feet, doubt creeping in again. "You sure you'll be fine?"

She didn't turn to him. "I'll be great, Captain Solo," she answered, and he could hear her smile in her answer. "Don't worry. Calamar will be good practice for Kha'art Hadash. If I can't cut it here, what chance will I have on the Smuggler's Moon?"

"Yeah," he answered, still unsure, but making for the door regardless. After a few steps, though, he hesitated: there was still the issue of the timeline. "How long is this gonna take? I mean, all of it? How long until you think we leave?"

"It takes as long as it takes," she answered, again in that lyrical tone.

His blood pressure spiked. "How *long*?" he growled.

This time, she craned her head around and took him in with a wily grin and twinkling eyes before turning back to her organizing. "I'm hoping for two weeks. That's all I should need."

Two weeks was plenty, maybe even too much time, but he figured, better that than having to rush anything. Pacified, he withdrew.

"And Captain Solo?" she chimed when he almost had one foot in the doorway.

He turned to face her, and the charming warmth had drained from her countenance. Instead, those tapered eyes bore through him again. "In the future," she started, one eyebrow arching as she lifted her chin, "you can point that finger someplace else." Her point made, she spun back around.

The vitriol he wanted to spit back at her once he finally recovered from the initial stun burned on his tongue. Who the fuck was she to talk like that to him, Hutt favorite or *woikeis* or whatever

the fuck she was?! And there it came, the beginnings of his heated response smoking out past his lips as he scowled.

His finger came up to emphasize. Seeing it, though, he paused. Deino and her dark purple eyes and taut jaw swirled in his mind's eye. *Don't do anything stupid*, those eyes had commanded.

Warned.

Though vexed, he forced the air out through his nose and holstered the gesture.